

WHWH Blog Post #1

Nature-Deficit Disorder: Reconnecting with Nature to Alleviate End-of-the-Year Stress

During times of high stress, impending deadlines, short days, and a realization of the year coming to an end, spending time focusing on self-care is crucial. One of the most important things that we often overlook is time spent in nature, outside. Although the days are getting colder and we might be getting busier, it is essential for us to take advantage of the limited time we have while the sun is out during the day and to spend time in a different environment. When people do not prioritize time in nature, many experience a phenomenon known as *Nature-Deficit Disorder*. Humans have a “biophilia”, suggested by Harvard biologist E.O. Wilson. We love nature, but when we do not have access, we become “distorted”. As a result, when we are stressed and anxious, connection with the outside environment can do wonders.



University College London, *Coping with Exam Stress*

Nature-Deficit Disorder is a non-medical diagnosis created by Richard Louv in 2005, which recognizes the increasing negative effects that increased time spent indoors has on the psychological, spiritual, physical, and social aspects of humans. Louv particularly focuses on how *Nature-Deficit Disorder* impacts children, noting that numerous schools “have contributed to a growing gap between nature and children” (Louv 2009). Louv observes that a prominent anthropological shift took place in the 1970s, when schools were stripped of their nature-involving structures by building windowless schools, disregarding animal integration in classrooms, and eliminating field trips. These changes were made as a result of the rise in “stranger-danger” fears among parents and educational/urban reform (Louv 2009). Louv coined the phrase “Nature-Deficit Disorder” to operate as a description of the negative effects faced by humans when experiencing ‘alienation’ from nature. Louv states it is not meant to be a medical

diagnosis; however, Louv believes it should be as a way to bring attention to the urgent problem that is growing among many individuals and groups. “Since 2005, this New Nature Movement has broadened to include adults and whole communities” (Louv 2016). The phrase became more well-known and is now a call to arms about the difficulties and struggles faced by the disorder across the globe. Louv summarized that, “Nature-deficit disorder is not a formal diagnosis, but a way to describe the psychological, physical and cognitive costs of human alienation from nature, particularly for children in their vulnerable developing years.” *Nature-deficit* is an inevitable set of symptoms that are bound to be experienced by humans, regardless of geography, race, sex, gender, age, social class, or economic background. When humans, especially students, do not interact enough with nature and do not embed their senses in all of the different ways nature can be perceived and sensed, then *Nature Deficiency* is expected to be experienced.



American Heart Association, *Spend Time in Nature to Reduce Stress and Anxiety*

Furthermore, the Human Environment Research Laboratory at the University of Illinois found compelling evidence for Nature’s support of improved behaviour. A 2004 Study in the American Journal of Public Health found that “children as young as five showed a significant reduction in ADHD symptoms when they engaged with nature” (Louv, 2005). This is powerful, specifically in the context of studying and time management. Although this specific period brings on a busy schedule, spending even a lively five minutes outside can help alleviate stress and help with focus.



University of Toronto Mississauga Nature Trail

So, as a student, where are different locations you can take some time to reconnect with nature? The answer is there are many places! Firstly, the University of Toronto Mississauga is privileged to have a nature trail that is near Principal Road, next to the Deerfield Hall building! Taking a walk on this beautiful trail will invite you to appreciate the gorgeous trees, the crisp and revitalizing weather, the calming sounds of the Credit River, and the fresh air. If you cannot make it to the UTM Trail, do not worry! Taking a walk around your neighbourhood, spending time in your backyard, or just breathing in air outside are all beneficial to help with *Nature-Deficit Disorder* and/or stress.

The Women's Health and Wellness Hub wishes you the best of luck with exams and the end of the Fall semester!

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